

THE GARAMUT



A MESSAGE SENDER

Ps Barry's Reflections on: **PRAYER, PROCLAMATION and PERSONAL PROGRESS**

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NO SWEET CANE WITH MONEY

Isaiah 43:24 You have not bought me sweet cane with money or satisfied me with the fat of your sacrifices. But you have burdened me with your sins; you have wearied me with your iniquities. ESV

When I read this verse, I was taken up with the specific phrase *"you have brought me no sweet cane with money"* and I wondered why that seemed to be significant to God.

What did the "sweet cane" mean and why was God looking for it in the offerings from his people were making to him?

"No Sweet Cane" For God

Isaiah 43:24 You have not bought me sweet cane with money or satisfied me with the fat of your sacrifices. But you have burdened me with your sins; you have wearied me with your iniquities. ESV

Isaiah 43:24 You did not buy me any sugar cane with your money or satisfy me with the best part of your sacrifices. Rather, you burdened me with your sins and troubled me with your wrongdoings. God's Word

THE OPENING STATEMENT, *"Thou hast bought me no sweet cane with money."* - REFERS TO THE LACK OF PROPER OFFERINGS BROUGHT TO GOD BY THE ISRAELITES.

SWEET CANE.

In ancient times, sweet cane was a fragrant plant used in making incense, and **it was often offered as a symbol of worship and honor to God.**

By not bringing **sweet cane with money**, the Israelites **failed to give God the reverence and adoration** he deserved.

SWEET CANE.

According to Jeremiah, this expensive delicacy came from "a far country"

Jeremiah 6:20 What do I care about incense from Sheba or sweet calamus from a distant land? Your burnt offerings are not acceptable; your sacrifices do not please me." NIV

It was one of the ingredients that God instructed Moses to use in the formula for the holy anointing oil - and it was used in the sanctuary to produce a sweet-smelling sacrifice. Exodus 30:23

Exodus 30:23 "Take the finest spices: twelve pounds of liquid myrrh, half that amount (that is, six pounds) of sweet-smelling cinnamon, six pounds of sweet-smelling cane, NCV.

An Israelite who brought sweet cane was expressing their sincere worship and reverence for God.

THE FAT.

The fat was the best part of an animal offering and had to be burned completely as a gift to Yahweh.

The fat referred to here is symbolic of the best part of the sacrifice being made and **the fat of the inner organs of the sacrifice is God's portion and is forbidden for man to eat it.**

Leviticus 7:25 Anyone who eats the fat of an animal from which an offering by fire may be made to the Lord must be cut off from his people. NIV

The application to Christians today is that we must give to our Creator the best we have to offer, and that includes our time and worship.

The Biblical meaning of **fat** (Hebrew word = "heleb") signifies the richest part of the animal, or the fattest of the flock, Easton's Bible Dictionary

THERE WAS SOMETHING MISSING IN ISRAEL'S OFFERINGS OF TO GOD.

- IT WAS the **"sweet cane"** that was missing that God was longing to see.
- The **"sweet cane"** symbolizes the element that makes the offering **sweet, pleasing and acceptable** to God.

GOD'S HEART REVEALED

In the way the scripture is written– *“You have not bought me sweet cane with money or satisfied me with the fat of your sacrifices”*, reveals the cry of God's heart and his longing for those two missing elements, the sweet cane and the fat and what they represented.

HE LONGED TO SEE THE SWEETNESS OF GENUINE REPENTANCE, OBEDIENCE AND REVERENCE TO THEIR GOD IN THEIR OFFERINGS.

His heart ACHED for the Sweet cane and the choicest part (the fat) that symbolized the SWEETNESS OF HUMILITY AND REVERENCE that his people should be offering to him.

IT WAS THE ABSENCE OF THESE TWO ELEMENTS, THAT DISAPPOINTED HIM.

HE MISSED from his people:

- The SWEETNESS of HUMILITY that expresses itself in a passionate desire to FOLLOW and PLEASE God.
- The SWEETNESS and PLEASANTNESS of OBEDIENCE.
- The SWEETNESS of SUBMISSION and RESPECT.
- The SWEETNESS of a SOFT HEART before God.
- He longed for the SWEETNESS OF AUTHENTIC WORSHIP AND DEVOTION TO HIM.

THESE WERE THE ELEMENTS THAT HE DESIRED HIS PEOPLE TO MAKE IN THEIR OFFERINGS TO HIM.

WHAT ABOUT US?

SURELY OUR LORD GOD WOULD ALSO DESIRE FROM US THOSE ELEMENTS OF SWEETNESS THAT MAKES HIS HEART PLEASED.

BUT HE WAS MADE TO SERVE WITH THEIR SINS.

“thou hast made me to serve with thy sins, thou hast wearied me with thine iniquities.”

- The sins and iniquities symbolize disobedience and rebellion.
- The sweet cane and fat symbolize sincere worship and surrender to God.

Isaiah 34:24 Suggests that the Israelites had BURDENED and WEARIED God with the weight of their transgressions, causing Him to endure their disobedience and unfaithfulness and emphasizing the need of GENUINE REPENTANCE and OBEDIENCE before him.

It also illustrates the importance of OFFERING SINCERE and HEARTFELT WORSHIP as well as the CONSEQUENCES OF neglecting to honor God with true REVERENCE.

THIS PASSAGE OF ISAIAH 34:24 CARRIES A TIMELESS MESSAGE THAT RESONATES WITH TODAY'S BELIEVERS, urging us to be certain that in offerings are filled with the presence of the SWEET CANE OF HUMILITY, REPENTANCE, SUBMISSION, WORSHIP AND REVERENCE TO GOD.

A personal testimony

Not long after I experienced the saving grace of Jesus in my life I was told

by a dear old brother in the Lord; *“Son, there is much more repentance after salvation than before”*

Which meant that after salvation we become more aware of how wrong our lives were and which results in us carrying a measure of sorrow that we were not aware of before salvation.

We must always bear in our lives the humility of repentance and some measure of sorrow for the way we lived before knowing God's salvation.

God's people gave money, but it was without those precious elements that God longed for – the sweet cane of the giving of themselves in their offerings.

The offering of our money and material possessions WITHOUT involving a COMMITMENT of ourselves to God does not satisfy him.

Our Lord longs for OUR HEART to be offered up with our offerings of WORSHIP and DEVOTION.

CHRIST'S OFFERING – IS OUR MODEL.

Christ's offering to his heavenly father was SWEET SMELLING and PLEASING to him because it included the giving of himself in his going to the Cross.

Ephesians 5:2 And walk in love, as Christ also hath loved us, and hath given himself for us an offering and a sacrifice to God for a sweetsmelling savour. KJV

Ephesians 5:2 and live a life of love, just as Christ loved us and gave himself up for us as a fragrant offering and sacrifice to God. NIV

Amen – Ps Barry